WILMINGTON DELAWARE STAKE RESOURCE GUIDE

# Finding Work

## A Job Search Resource Guide

Resumes · Cover Letters · Job Boards · Recruiters · Interviews
Second Chances · Senior Placement · Social Services

**Wilmington Delaware Stake**
Cecil · Harford · Kent, Maryland
New Castle, Delaware · Lancaster · Chester, Pennsylvania
October 2026

> *Far and away the best prize that life offers is the chance to work hard at work worth doing.*
>
> — Theodore Roosevelt, Labor Day address, Syracuse, New York, September 7, 1903

All services listed are free. Phone numbers and hours change — call to confirm before you visit.

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# How to Use This Guide

Treat the job search like a part-time job: 3 to 4 focused hours a day, five days a week, using every free tool in this guide. It is written for anyone looking for work, especially people starting over, coming back after time away, or getting by on little or no income while they search.

> *Trust in the Lord with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding. In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths.*
>
> — Proverbs 3:5–6

Every service listed here is free. If anyone asks you to pay to apply, pay for training up front, or pay a recruiter to place you, walk away.

This guide covers the six counties of the Wilmington Delaware Stake: **Cecil, Harford and Kent** in Maryland; **New Castle** in Delaware; and **Lancaster and Chester** in Pennsylvania. Use the job center and benefits office for the county where you live. If you file for unemployment, file in the state where you worked.

## Your First Week

☐ **Day 1:** Call **211** (or text your ZIP code to 898-211) to ask about food, rent, and utility help so money stress doesn't derail the search.

☐ **Day 1:** If you were laid off, file for unemployment the same week and ask your job center about dislocated-worker programs that can pay for retraining.

☐ **Day 2:** Gather your ID, Social Security card, and work history (see Getting Ready).

☐ **Day 2:** Set up a professional email address and a voicemail greeting.

☐ **Day 3:** Visit or call your local American Job Center or PA CareerLink and register on your state's job site.

☐ **Day 3–4:** Write one master resume and one master cover letter; get them reviewed at the job center or library.

☐ **Day 4:** Create profiles on two or three job boards and set up daily job alerts.

☐ **Day 5:** Register with two staffing agencies that place people in your field.

☐ **Every day:** Apply to a few jobs that fit, and log each one in a simple tracker.

☐ **Every week:** Tell five people you know that you are looking. Most jobs are still found through someone you know.

**About this guide.** Compiled by volunteers of the Wilmington Delaware Stake as a free community service for anyone in Cecil, Harford and Kent counties (Maryland), New Castle County (Delaware), and Lancaster and Chester counties (Pennsylvania). It is not an official publication of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, and listing an organization is not an endorsement. It is not legal advice, and no job, wage, benefit or training slot is guaranteed. Information was checked in October 2026, but programs, phone numbers, hours, dollar amounts and rules change often. Always call to confirm before you travel, apply or rely on any figure. Every program listed serves people of any faith or no faith.

# Getting Ready

Most hiring stalls on paperwork, not skills: an employer must see your ID and work eligibility on your first day (Form I-9), so get these in hand before you interview.

> *...if ye are prepared ye shall not fear.*
>
> — Doctrine and Covenants 38:30

| Need | What to have | Where to get it if missing |
|---|---|---|
| Photo ID | State driver's license or ID card | Your state motor vehicle office (MD MVA, DE DMV, PennDOT); ask a caseworker or 211 about fee waivers |
| Work eligibility | Social Security card (or a passport) | Free replacement at ssa.gov |
| Birth certificate | Often needed to get the ID above | Vital records office of the state where you were born |
| Work history | Employers, dates, duties, supervisor names | Write it down from memory; old pay stubs and tax forms help |
| Phone | A number with voicemail you check daily | Free or discounted service through the federal Lifeline program (lifelinesupport.org) if you get SNAP, Medicaid, or similar |
| Email | Simple and professional, built from your real name: firstname.lastname@gmail.com. No nicknames, jokes, hobbies, or long, confusing strings | Free at any email provider; check it every day. If your name is taken, add a 2–4 digit number you will always remember (john.smith0385@gmail.com) |
| Address | Somewhere mail reliably reaches you | A trusted friend or relative, a shelter or day center, or General Delivery at your post office |
| Clothes | One clean, simple interview outfit | Thrift stores, church clothing closets, Career Wardrobe (Kennett Square, PA), job center referrals |
| Transportation | A reliable way to get to work | Map the bus route before you apply (Cecil Transit, Harford LINK, MUST Bus, DART, Red Rose Transit, SEPTA/SCCOOT); ask the job center about gas cards or bus passes |

## Tips

- Record a plain voicemail greeting: your first and last name and "please leave a message."
- Keep copies of every document in one folder, plus photos of them on your phone.

- Public libraries offer free computers, printing, Wi-Fi, and often one-on-one job help.
- **Know the minimum wage (2026):** Maryland $15.00 an hour; Delaware $15.00; Pennsylvania $7.25. Many Pennsylvania employers pay more — compare offers.

# Building a Solid Resume

A good resume is one page, plain, and easy to scan in 10 seconds. Hiring managers and the software many companies use to screen applications both favor simple formatting and clear words over fancy design.

> *Whatsoever thy hand findeth to do, do it with thy might.*
>
> — Ecclesiastes 9:10

## What Goes on It, in Order

1. **Contact line:** name, city and state, phone, email. A full street address is not needed.
2. **Summary (2–3 lines):** what you do and what you're looking for. Example: *Dependable warehouse worker with 4 years of forklift and shipping experience, seeking a full-time day-shift role.*
3. **Skills:** 6–10 specific items: equipment, software, certifications, languages, licenses (CDL, forklift, ServSafe, CNA).
4. **Work experience:** most recent first. Job title, employer, city, month and year started and ended, then 2–4 bullets per job.
5. **Education and training:** diploma or GED, trade programs, certificates. Leave off graduation years if you prefer.

## Writing Strong Bullets

Start each bullet with an action word and add a number when you can.

| Weak | Strong |
|---|---|
| Responsible for cash register | Handled $3,000+ in daily cash and card sales with zero shortages |
| Did cleaning | Cleaned and restocked 40 hotel rooms per shift to inspection standard |
| Helped customers | Answered 60+ customer calls a day and resolved most on the first call |

## If You Have Little Experience or Short Gaps

- Count everything: volunteer work, church service, caring for a family member, odd jobs, gig work, school projects, military service.
- Put a short, honest reason on gaps if asked: *Family caregiver, 2023–2025* or *Returned to school*. Don't lie; just don't over-explain.
- Lead with a skills section if your work history is thin.
- For longer gaps, incarceration, or recovery, see *Explaining Larger Gaps and a Hard History*.

## Formatting Rules

- Use a plain font (Calibri, Arial) at 10.5–12 pt, with normal margins.
- No photos, tables, graphics, or columns; screening software can scramble them.
- Save as PDF unless the posting asks for Word. Name it *Firstname-Lastname-Resume.pdf*.
- Tweak the summary and skills for each job, using the same words the posting uses.
- Have someone else proofread. One typo can cost an interview.

**Free templates and help:** Google Docs and Microsoft Word both include free resume templates (choose the simplest one). Your American Job Center, PA CareerLink, and many public libraries will review your resume one-on-one for free. CareerOneStop.org also has a step-by-step resume guide.

## References

Choose three people who have seen you work (supervisors, coworkers, teachers, volunteer leaders, church leaders). Ask permission first, tell them what jobs you are applying for, and keep their names, titles, phone numbers, and emails on a separate page titled *References*.

# Writing a Cover Letter

A cover letter is a short, one-page letter that goes with your resume. The resume lists what you have done; the cover letter tells one employer, in your own voice, why you want *this* job and why you are a good fit. A good one can get you an interview over someone with a similar resume, and it is the best place to show reliability, attitude, and interest that a resume can't.

> *Verily I say, men should be anxiously engaged in a good cause, and do many things of their own free will, and bring to pass much righteousness.*
>
> — Doctrine and Covenants 58:27

## When to Send One

- **Always** when the posting asks for one, and whenever an online application has a box or upload for it.
- **Usually** for office, healthcare, skilled, supervisory, school, and government jobs.
- **Optional** for walk-in, hourly, and staffing-agency applications — but a short note still helps you stand out.
- If the application has no place for it, paste a shortened version into the email or "additional information" box.

## The Four Parts

| Part | What to write | Length |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Greeting | "Dear Ms. Rivera:" — use the hiring manager's name if you can find it (posting, company website, or a quick call to the front desk). Otherwise: "Dear Hiring Manager:" | 1 line |
| 2. Opening | The job title, where you saw it (or who referred you), and one sentence on why you want it | 2–3 sentences |
| 3. Why you fit | One or two short examples that match what the posting asks for. Use numbers when you can. Mention a certification, schedule flexibility, or reliability | 1–2 short paragraphs |
| 4. Closing | Thank them, say you would welcome an interview, and give your phone and email | 2–3 sentences |

## Step by Step

1. **Read the posting twice** and circle the 3–4 things they want most (skills, schedule, certifications, qualities).
2. **Match each one** to something you have done — a job, volunteer role, training, or church calling.

3. **Write a master letter** using the four parts. Keep it under one page: about 200–300 words.
4. **Customize it for every job.** Change the company name, job title, and your examples. Use the same words the posting uses. Never send a letter with the wrong company name.
5. **Format it simply:** same font as your resume, your name and contact line at the top, the date, then the letter. Save it as *Firstname-Lastname-Cover-Letter.pdf*.
6. **Proofread out loud**, then have someone else read it. Ask the job center or library staff to review it with your resume.

## Sample Cover Letter

Adapt this; don't copy it word for word. Employers can tell when a letter is generic.

> **Jordan Smith** · Elkton, MD · 410-555-0142 · jordan.smith0385@gmail.com
> October 12, 2026
>
> Dear Ms. Rivera:
>
> I am applying for the Warehouse Associate position at Northeast Distribution that I saw on Indeed. I have lived in Cecil County most of my life, and I would be proud to work for a company with a reputation for promoting from within.
>
> For the past four years I worked at a regional parts supplier, where I picked and packed an average of 150 orders a shift with a 99% accuracy rate and was trusted to train six new employees. I hold a current forklift certification and have never missed a scheduled shift. I can work days, evenings, or weekends, and I live 10 minutes from your facility.
>
> Thank you for considering my application. I would welcome the chance to talk with you about how I can help your team meet its shipping goals. I can be reached at 410-555-0142 or jordan.smith0385@gmail.com.
>
> Sincerely,
> Jordan Smith

## If You Have a Gap, a Career Change, or a Record

- **Keep it positive and short.** A cover letter is not the place to explain a conviction or health history in detail. Focus on what you can do now.
- **Gap:** one sentence is enough if you choose to mention it: *"After two years as a full-time caregiver for my father, I am ready to return to full-time work."*
- **Career change:** connect old skills to the new job: *"Ten years in retail taught me to stay calm with upset customers — exactly what your call center needs."*
- **New skills:** name recent training: *"I recently completed a CNA course through the job center."*

- **Record:** save the conversation for the interview (see the next section). If you have a Federal Bonding letter or a reentry program reference, you may mention: *“I am eligible for the Federal Bonding Program at no cost to your company.”*

## Do and Don’t

| Do | Don’t |
|---|---|
| Address a real person when you can | Start with “To Whom It May Concern” if a name is easy to find |
| Name the exact job title and company | Send the same letter to everyone |
| Give one or two specific examples with numbers | Repeat your whole resume |
| Show you want *this* job | Talk about how badly you need money or any job |
| Keep it to one page, three or four short paragraphs | Write more than one page or use fancy fonts and colors |
| Mention availability and reliability | Mention pay, vacation, or benefits |
| Proofread and check the company name | Leave typos or another company’s name in the letter |

## Emailing Your Application

- **Subject line:** *Application – Warehouse Associate – Jordan Smith*
- Put a short version of the cover letter in the body of the email, then attach your resume and the full letter as PDFs.
- Use a greeting and sign-off just like a letter, and include your phone number under your name.

- ☐ Correct company name, job title, and hiring manager name
- ☐ Two or three matches to what the posting asks for
- ☐ One page, same font as the resume, saved as PDF
- ☐ Contact information at the top and in the closing
- ☐ Proofread out loud and by a second person

# Explaining Larger Gaps and a Hard History

A long gap or a past mistake rarely ends a job search; how you explain it decides most outcomes. Employers mainly want to know three things: that you are honest, that the problem is behind you, and that you will show up and work hard now.

> *However late you think you are, however many chances you think you have missed, however many mistakes you feel you have made or talents you think you don't have, or however far from home and family and God you feel you have traveled, I testify that you have not traveled beyond the reach of divine love.*
>
> — Elder Jeffrey R. Holland, "The Laborers in the Vineyard," general conference, April 2012

## The Three-Part Answer

Use the same short, practiced answer every time, on applications and in interviews:

1. **Own it briefly** (one sentence, no excuses or details).
2. **Show what changed** (what you did, learned, or completed).
3. **Turn to the job** (why you are ready and a good fit now).

Keep it under 30 seconds, then stop talking and let them ask more if they want to. Practice it out loud until it sounds calm and natural.

| Situation | Example answer |
|---|---|
| Incarceration | "I made a poor decision in 2021 and served 3 years. I took responsibility, finished my GED and a forklift certification while I was inside, and I've been working with a reentry program since. I'm ready to work, and I want to prove myself here." |
| Substance use recovery | "I took time away from work to deal with a personal health matter, and it's fully behind me. Since then I've completed a training program and volunteered weekly at my church. I'm ready to commit to a full-time schedule." |
| Health problem or injury | "I had a medical issue that took me out of work for a year. I'm fully cleared now and ready for full-time hours." |
| Caregiving | "I was the full-time caregiver for my mother until she passed. That's taught me patience and responsibility, and now I'm ready to return to work." |
| Homelessness or a long, unexplained gap | "I went through a hard stretch financially and focused on getting back on my feet. I'm in stable housing now, I've been taking classes at the job center, and I'm ready to work." |

## What You Do and Don’t Have to Share

- **Never lie** on an application or in an interview. A background check will usually find a conviction, and a lie can cost you the job or get you fired later, even when the record itself would not have.
- **Recovery and health are private.** You do not have to name a diagnosis, addiction, or treatment. “A personal health matter that is behind me” is honest and enough. Under the Americans with Disabilities Act, employers generally cannot ask about medical history before making a job offer, and people in recovery who are not currently using illegal drugs have protections.
- **Answer only the question asked.** If an application asks about convictions in the last 7 years, don’t list older ones or arrests that weren’t convictions.
- **Keep paperwork handy:** certificates, program completion letters, a letter from a probation officer, counselor, employer, or bishop vouching for you.

## Your Rights and Helpful Laws

- **Maryland “Ban the Box”:** employers with 15 or more full-time employees may not ask about a criminal record until the first in-person interview (exceptions apply for jobs with children or vulnerable adults and where law requires it). Use the first interview to make a strong impression before the subject comes up.
- **Maryland record clearing:** many charges and some convictions can be expunged or shielded by petition. Ask Maryland Legal Aid (1-888-465-2468) or your job center’s reentry staff to review your record.
- **Delaware Clean Slate:** the law allows automatic expungement of many eligible records, but as of 2026 the state had processed only a small share of eligible cases. Don’t wait — ask about filing a petition through the Office of Defense Services (ods.delaware.gov/expungements) or CleanSlateDE.org.
- **Pennsylvania Clean Slate:** many older, lower-level records are sealed automatically (summary offenses after 5 years, many misdemeanors after 7, and some drug felonies after 10 crime-free years); others can be sealed by petition. Employers generally cannot see a sealed record. Free help: MidPenn Legal Services (Lancaster, 1-800-326-9177) and Legal Aid of Southeastern PA (Chester, 877-429-5994), or palegalaid.net.
- **Federal Bonding Program:** a free fidelity bond (usually $5,000) that covers the employer for your first 6 months when it hires someone with a record, a history of substance use, poor credit, or no work history. It costs neither you nor the employer anything. Ask your job center or CareerLink for a bonding letter and mention it in interviews (bonds4jobs.com).

## Where to Look for Jobs

- **Fair-chance employers:** many warehouses, manufacturers, construction and trade contractors, restaurants, landscaping, moving, and recycling companies hire people with

records. Ask the job center's reentry or business services staff which local employers are open to it.

- **Staffing agencies** often place people with records in temp-to-hire jobs, where your work speaks before your past.
- **Reentry help by state:**
  - Maryland: Maryland Department of Labor Re-Entry Initiative (410-767-2173) through any American Job Center.
  - Delaware: ReEntry Delaware (302-275-2779); Delaware Center for Justice (302-658-7174, by referral); Goodwill Opportunity Hub reentry support (302-761-4640).
  - Lancaster: PA CareerLink Lancaster hosts reentry support; also ask your probation or parole officer.
  - Chester: Chester County Adult Probation & Parole Reentry Services (610-344-6000) and Chester County OIC in Coatesville (610-692-2344).
- **Recovery-friendly workplaces:** ask your counselor or recovery program about employers that support people in recovery.
- **Start somewhere:** a first job, even part-time, builds a new reference and a recent work record. After 6 to 12 months, the gap matters much less.

> *I have learned that success is to be measured not so much by the position that one has reached in life as by the obstacles which he has overcome while trying to succeed.*
>
> — Booker T. Washington, *Up from Slavery* (1901), chapter 2

# Job Boards

Start with your state's free job site, then add two or three national boards; applying to fewer jobs that truly fit beats mass-applying to everything.

> *Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you.*
>
> — Matthew 7:7

| Site | Best for | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Maryland Workforce Exchange (mwejobs.maryland.gov) | Maryland jobs, training funds | Resume builder, job alerts, and a weekly job-contact log; required if you collect Maryland unemployment |
| Delaware JobLink (joblink.delaware.gov) | Delaware jobs, training funds | Free resume wizard, job alerts, and a list of job fairs and workshops |
| PA CareerLink (pacareerlink.pa.gov) | Pennsylvania jobs, training funds | Also connects you to SNAP, TANF, veteran, and vocational rehab services |
| Indeed (indeed.com) | The widest mix of local jobs | Upload your resume; set daily email alerts by job title and ZIP code |
| LinkedIn (linkedin.com/jobs) | Office, skilled, and professional roles | Fill out your profile fully; recruiters search it |
| ZipRecruiter (ziprecruiter.com) | Fast applications | Many one-click applications; follow up directly with employers |
| Snagajob (snagajob.com) | Hourly, retail, food service, warehouse | Good for quick-start jobs |
| USAJOBS (usajobs.gov) | Federal jobs (Aberdeen Proving Ground, Perry Point and Coatesville VA, Dover AFB) | Slower hiring; follow each posting's instructions exactly |
| Company career pages | Hospitals (ChristianaCare, Penn Medicine, UM Upper Chesapeake, Lancaster General), school districts, county government, large local employers | Often post jobs here first; check weekly |

## How to Search Well

- Search by several job titles, not just one (for example: *warehouse associate*, *material handler*, *picker packer*).

- Filter by distance from your ZIP code and by “posted in the last 3 days.” Early applicants get more calls.
- Read the posting twice. Mirror its words in your resume and cover letter, and only apply if you meet most of the requirements.
- Apply directly on the company’s own website when you can, then follow up by phone or email within a week.
- Walk-in applications still work for restaurants, retail, and some trades. Go mid-morning or mid-afternoon, never during a rush.

## Avoiding Job Scams

Job scams have grown sharply. The Federal Trade Commission advises verifying every opening and never paying for the promise of a job. Walk away if:

- They hire you without an interview, or the “interview” is only by text or chat.
- They ask you to pay for training, equipment, a background check, or a starter kit.
- They send you a check and ask you to deposit it and send part of the money back.
- The job is reshipping packages from your home.
- They want your bank login or Social Security number before a real offer.
- They email from a personal account (Gmail, Yahoo) and the pay seems too good to be true.

Report scams at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.

## Track Every Application

Keep a simple log in a notebook or spreadsheet: date, company, job title, how you applied, contact name, and follow-up date. It keeps you organized and shows which approaches are getting responses.

| Date | Company | Job title | How applied | Contact | Follow up on | Result |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |

# Recruiters and Staffing Agencies

Staffing agencies are often the fastest way back to a paycheck, sometimes within days, and many temporary jobs turn permanent. A legitimate agency is paid by the employer; you never pay to be placed.

> *The world has need of willing men*
> *Who wear the worker's seal.*
> *Come, help the good work move along;*
> *Put your shoulder to the wheel.*
>
> — "Put Your Shoulder to the Wheel," *Hymns*, no. 252 (Will L. Thompson)

## The Three Kinds

| Type | How it works | Good for |
|---|---|---|
| Day labor / on-demand | Show up or use an app; work the same or next day, often paid daily or weekly | Immediate income: construction cleanup, events, moving, warehouse |
| Temp and temp-to-hire | Agency places you at a company for weeks or months; you may be hired on permanently after 60–90 days | Warehouse, manufacturing, office, call center, light industrial |
| Direct-hire recruiters | Recruiter finds you a permanent job; the employer pays the recruiter's fee | Skilled trades, healthcare, IT, accounting, management |

Well-known national agencies include Adecco, Manpower, Kelly Services, Randstad, Express Employment Professionals, Aerotek, Robert Half (office and finance), and PeopleReady (day labor). Search *staffing agency* plus your town (Elkton, Aberdeen, Bel Air, Chestertown, Newark, Wilmington, Lancaster, Exton, Coatesville) to find local offices, and check reviews.

## How to Work with Them

1. **Register in person when you can.** Bring your ID, Social Security card, and resume. Expect a short interview, skills test, and paperwork.
2. **Be clear about what you want:** shifts, pay, distance, and the type of work.
3. **Register with two or three agencies,** not ten. You want recruiters who know you.
4. **Check in every week** by phone or text: "I'm still available for day or evening shifts." The people who check in get the calls.
5. **Treat every assignment like an audition.** Show up early, every day. Temp workers who are reliable are the ones offered permanent jobs.
6. **On LinkedIn,** turn on *Open to Work* (visible to recruiters only if you prefer) and answer recruiter messages promptly and politely.

## Questions to Ask Before You Accept

- What is the hourly pay, and when and how am I paid?
- How long is the assignment, and is it temp-to-hire?
- What are the hours, the location, and the dress or safety-gear requirements?
- Does the agency offer health insurance or other benefits?

## Red Flags

- Any fee to register, train, or place you.
- Pressure to sign right away without reading the paperwork.
- A “recruiter” who only communicates by text and won’t give a company name or office address.

# Free Job Help Near You

Your local American Job Center (called PA CareerLink in Pennsylvania) is the single best free resource: one visit gets you resume and cover letter help, computers and printers, workshops, job leads, and possible funding for training. Anywhere in the U.S., find the nearest one at CareerOneStop.org/LocalHelp or by calling 1-877-872-5627.

> *Two are better than one; because they have a good reward for their labour. For if they fall, the one will lift up his fellow.*
>
> — Ecclesiastes 4:9–10

## Job Centers in Our Stake

| County | Center | Address | Phone |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cecil, MD | Susquehanna Workforce Center – Elkton | 1275 West Pulaski Hwy, Elkton, MD 21921 | 410-996-0550 (Mon–Fri 8–4:30) |
| Harford, MD | Susquehanna Workforce Center – Swan Creek | 2129 Pulaski Hwy, Suite 101, Havre de Grace, MD 21078 | 410-272-5400 (Mon–Fri 8–4:30) |
| Kent, MD | Kent County American Job Center (Upper Shore Workforce) | 115A S. Lynchburg St, Chestertown, MD 21620 | 410-778-3525 (Mon and Fri 8–4; call first) |
| New Castle, DE | Delaware JobLink – Newark | 252 Chapman Rd, Christiana Bldg, 2nd floor, Newark, DE 19702 | 302-368-6622 |
| New Castle, DE | Delaware JobLink – Wilmington (Fox Valley) | 4425 North Market St, Wilmington, DE 19802 | 302-761-8085 |
| Lancaster, PA | PA CareerLink Lancaster County | 1046 Manheim Pike, Lancaster, PA 17601 | 717-509-5613 (Mon–Fri 8:30–5) |
| Chester, PA | PA CareerLink Chester County | 479 Thomas Jones Way, Suite 500, Exton, PA 19341 | 610-280-1010 |

Call ahead to confirm hours. Bring a photo ID and a copy of your resume if you have one.

## What They Can Do for You

- One-on-one help with your resume, cover letter, applications, and interview practice.
- Free computers, internet, printing, copying, and phones for job searching.
- Workshops on job search, computer basics, and interview skills.
- Job fairs and direct referrals to employers who are hiring.
- **Paid training (WIOA):** if you qualify, federal funds can pay tuition for short certificate programs such as CDL, welding, HVAC, medical assistant, CNA, or IT. Ask to meet with a

WIOA career counselor.

- **Apprenticeships:** earn a paycheck while you learn a trade.
- Special help for veterans, people with disabilities, older workers, young adults (16–24), and people returning from incarceration.

## Community Colleges and Trade Schools

| County | School | Contact |
|---|---|---|
| Cecil | Cecil College Continuing Education & Workforce Development, 107 Railroad Ave, Elkton | 410-287-1078 |
| Harford | Harford Community College Workforce Training Center at Water's Edge, Belcamp | 443-412-2000 |
| Kent | Chesapeake College Continuing Education & Workforce Training (serves Kent County) | 410-827-5850 |
| New Castle | Delaware Technical Community College – Stanton (Newark) / Wilmington campuses | 302-454-3900 / 302-571-5300 |
| Lancaster | HACC Workforce Development · Thaddeus Stevens College of Technology (Stevens Grant for eligible students) | 717-221-1332 · 717-299-7701 |
| Chester | Delaware County Community College Workforce & Economic Development (Downingtown, West Grove sites) | 610-355-7156 |

## Libraries

| County | Library | Phone |
|---|---|---|
| Cecil | Cecil County Public Library (Elkton, North East, and branches) | 410-996-1055 |
| Harford | Harford County Public Library – Bel Air, 100 E. Pennsylvania Ave (also Aberdeen, Edgewood, Havre de Grace) | 410-638-3151 |
| Kent | Kent County Public Library – Chestertown, 408 High St (also North County and Rock Hall) | 410-778-3636 |
| New Castle | Wilmington Public Library, 10 E. 10th St · free Delaware Libraries Job/Career Hub phone sessions (guides.lib.de.us/jobs) | 302-571-7400 |
| Lancaster | Lancaster Public Library, 151 N. Queen St | 717-394-2651 |
| Chester | Chester County Library Business & Career Center, 450 Exton Square Pkwy, Exton (CareerLink drop-in Tuesdays 12–3) | 610-344-5947 |

## More Free Help

- **Your ward and stake:** talk with your bishop or the ward or stake self-reliance specialist about joining a *Find a Better Job* self-reliance group. It teaches networking, a 30-second introduction, resumes, and interviewing, and is open to people of any faith.

- **Nonprofit job programs:** Goodwill Opportunity Hub, Wilmington (302-761-4640); SACA Tec Centro, Lancaster — bilingual training, GED and ESL (717-509-6679); Goodwill Keystone Area Employment Services, Lancaster, for people with disabilities or other barriers (1-800-432-4483); Chester County OIC, Coatesville — training, GED, driver's education, work clothing (610-692-2344).
- **Interview clothing:** Career Wardrobe, Kennett Square, serves men and women (215-568-6693 ext. 28). Elsewhere, ask your job center or call 211 for a clothing closet.
- **Vocational rehabilitation** (for people with a disability or health condition): Maryland DORS (Elkton 410-996-0620; Bel Air 410-836-7636), Delaware Division of Vocational Rehabilitation (Newark 302-368-6980; Wilmington 302-761-8275), and Pennsylvania OVR (York office for Lancaster 717-771-4407; Norristown office for Chester 484-250-4340) provide free job coaching, training, and equipment.
- **Job Corps:** free job training for ages 16–24. Nearest center: Wilmington Job Corps, 9 Vandever Ave (302-575-1710); national line 1-800-733-5627.
- **Veterans:** every job center has a veterans' representative, and veterans get priority of service. Maryland veterans employment line 410-767-2015.

# Job Placement for Seniors (55 and Older)

Older workers bring what employers say they can't find: reliability, judgment, and a strong work ethic. The best first step for a low-income senior is the Senior Community Service Employment Program (SCSEP), which pays you to train in a real job.

> *The great affairs of life are not performed by physical strength, or activity, or nimbleness of body, but by deliberation, character, expression of opinion. Of these old age is not only not deprived, but, as a rule, has them in a greater degree.*
>
> — Marcus Tullius Cicero, *On Old Age* (44 B.C.), section 6, translated by E. S. Shuckburgh

## SCSEP: Paid Training for Ages 55+

- **What it is:** part-time work experience at a nonprofit or government agency (schools, hospitals, senior centers, libraries), averaging about 20 hours a week at minimum wage, plus job-search help toward a permanent job.
- **Who qualifies:** age 55 or older, unemployed, and household income at or below 125% of the federal poverty level. Veterans and people 65+, with a disability, or facing other barriers get priority.

| County | Where to apply |
|---|---|
| Cecil, MD | CWI Works – Maryland (Center for Workforce Inclusion), 410-801-6088; or ask the Susquehanna Workforce Center in Elkton (410-996-0550) |
| Harford, MD | CWI Works – Maryland, 410-801-6088; or the Swan Creek job center (410-272-5400) |
| Kent, MD | Maryland Department of Labor SCSEP Interest Line, 410-767-2396 |
| New Castle, DE | Goodwill of Delaware and Delaware County, 300 E. Lea Blvd, Wilmington, 1-866-317-2299 |
| Lancaster, PA | AARP Foundation SCSEP, 1-855-850-2525; Lancaster County Office of Aging 55+ Job Bank and workshops (1st and 3rd Wednesdays), 717-299-7979 |
| Chester, PA | AARP Foundation SCSEP, 1-855-850-2525; referrals through Chester County Department of Aging Services, 610-344-6350 |

## Other Help for Older Job Seekers

- American Job Centers serve every age, and older workers can get WIOA-funded training too. Ask for an older-worker specialist.
- AARP Foundation runs SCSEP sites and free job-search programs for people 50+ (aarp.org/work); its job board lists age-friendly employers.
- **Good-fit jobs:** school bus driver, crossing guard, library or museum aide, retail and grocery, bank teller, receptionist, hospital transport or volunteer coordinator, tax-season

preparer, security guard, home care companion, delivery driver, and part-time trade or consulting work in your old field.

## Tips for the Search

- **Show you are current:** list recent training, computer skills, and any certifications. Free basic computer and smartphone classes are offered at libraries and job centers.
- **Trim the resume:** show the last 10–15 years of work in detail; summarize older jobs in one line or leave them off. Leave off graduation years.
- **Lead with reliability and flexibility:** mention that you are available for the shifts they need and bring years of dependable work.
- **Use your network:** former coworkers, church members, and community groups are often the fastest route to a job.
- **Know your rights:** the federal Age Discrimination in Employment Act protects workers 40 and older from age discrimination in hiring and pay.

## Working While on Social Security

If you take Social Security before full retirement age (67 for anyone born in 1960 or later), earnings above **$24,480 in 2026** cause $1 in benefits to be withheld for every $2 earned over the limit. In the year you reach full retirement age, the limit is $65,160 and $1 is withheld for every $3. Withheld benefits are not lost; your monthly check is raised once you reach full retirement age. From the month you reach full retirement age, there is no earnings limit. Check your situation with Social Security (1-800-772-1213) before accepting a job.

# Social Services While You Look

Apply for every benefit you may qualify for in your first week. These programs exist to keep you housed, fed, and healthy while you get back to work, and many applications take weeks to process.

> *Fear not, I am with thee; oh, be not dismayed,*
> *For I am thy God and will still give thee aid.*
> *I'll strengthen thee, help thee, and cause thee to stand,*
> *Upheld by my righteous, omnipotent hand.*
>
> — "How Firm a Foundation," *Hymns*, no. 85

## Start Here: 211

Dial **211** (free, 24/7) or text your ZIP code to 898-211 to reach a trained specialist who can connect you to food, rent and utility help, shelter, transportation, and local job programs in Maryland, Delaware, or Pennsylvania.

## If You Are Collecting Unemployment

File in the state where you worked: Maryland BEACON (667-207-6520), Delaware (302-761-8446), Pennsylvania (1-888-313-7284). Your state's job site and job center are part of the deal: Maryland requires registration on the Maryland Workforce Exchange with a resume employers can see, Delaware requires a Delaware JobLink account, and Pennsylvania requires PA CareerLink registration. Use these requirements to your advantage: the job center's workshops, resume reviews, and staff-assisted searches all count as job-search activity and lead to real placements.

## Where to Apply for Food, Cash, and Medical Help

| County | Office | Phone | Apply online |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cecil, MD | Cecil County Department of Social Services, 170 E. Main St, Elkton | 410-996-0100 | MarylandBenefits.gov |
| Harford, MD | Harford County DSS, 2 S. Bond St, Suite 300, Bel Air | 410-836-4700 | MarylandBenefits.gov |
| Kent, MD | Kent County DSS, 350 High St, Chestertown | 410-810-7600 | MarylandBenefits.gov |
| New Castle, DE | DHSS State Service Centers (Newark, Wilmington, New Castle, Claymont, Middletown) | 302-255-9040 | assist.dhss.delaware.gov |
| Lancaster, PA | Lancaster County Assistance Office, 832 Manor St | 717-299-7411 | compass.state.pa.us |
| Chester, PA | Chester County Assistance Office, 100 James Buchanan Dr, Thorndale | 610-466-1000 | compass.state.pa.us |

## Programs to Ask About

| Program | What it does | Where |
|---|---|---|
| SNAP (food stamps) | Monthly grocery money on an EBT card; ask for expedited SNAP if you have almost no cash | County office or online portal above |
| TANF / TCA (cash assistance) | Monthly cash for families with children, plus job-training support | Same offices |
| Medicaid / Medical Assistance | Free or low-cost health coverage for low-income adults and families | Same portals; also Maryland Health Connection, HealthCare.gov (DE), or Pennie (PA) |
| WIC | Food, formula, and nutrition help for pregnant women and children under 5 | Your county health department |
| Energy assistance (LIHEAP, MEAP, EUSP) | Help paying heating and electric bills, including shut-off notices | State portals above, or call 211 |
| Child care subsidy | Pays part of child care while you work, train, or search | MD Child Care Scholarship · DE Purchase of Care · PA Child Care Works |
| Lifeline | Discounted phone or internet service | lifelinesupport.org |

## SNAP Work Rules Changed

Under the 2025 federal budget law, adults 18 to 64 who can work and have no child under 14 in the home must now work, train, or volunteer at least 80 hours a month to keep SNAP longer than 3 months in a 3-year period. Veterans, people experiencing homelessness, and former foster youth are no longer exempt.

- Job center training, workshops, and supervised job search often count toward the 80 hours. Ask your caseworker which activities qualify.
- Report any health condition that limits your work; it may exempt you.
- Respond to every letter from your benefits office by its deadline.
- For more detail on benefits in every county, see the stake's *Community Assistance Resource Guide*.

## Help from the Ward

Talk with your bishop about short-term help with food and other essentials, and with your ward or stake self-reliance specialist about a job-search plan and a Self-Reliance Plan for your household budget. Ward members are also one of the best networks for job leads.

# Interviews: Preparing, Behaving, and Following Up

Most interviews are won before you walk in the door. Hiring managers decide largely on three things: whether you can do the job, whether you will show up and work hard, and whether you will get along with the team. Every part of your preparation should answer those three questions.

> *Be strong and of a good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the Lord thy God is with thee whithersoever thou goest.*
>
> — Joshua 1:9

## Preparing: The Week Before

1. **Study the job.** Print the posting and circle every skill or duty it lists. For each one, think of a time you did something similar.
2. **Research the company.** Read its website, recent news, and reviews. Know what it does, who its customers are, and where the job is located.
3. **Write your 30-second introduction.** Who you are, your strongest experience or skill, and why you want this job. Practice it until it sounds natural, not memorized.
4. **Prepare 5–6 short stories about your work,** each with the situation, what you did, and how it turned out: a problem you solved; a time you worked hard under pressure; a time you dealt with a difficult customer or coworker; a mistake you made and what you learned; something you learned quickly; and a time you went beyond what was asked.
5. **Prepare your gap or background answer** using the three-part method in *Explaining Larger Gaps and a Hard History*.
6. **Do a mock interview.** Ask a friend, family member, ward member, or job center staff to interview you. Many job centers and the Chester County Library offer practice interviews for free.
7. **Write 3–4 questions to ask them** (see below).

## Preparing: The Day Before

- Lay out your clothes: clean, pressed, and one step dressier than the job's daily dress. For most jobs: slacks or khakis, a collared shirt or blouse, clean closed-toe shoes.
- Plan your route and do a test run if you can. Plan to arrive 10–15 minutes early, not earlier.
- Pack a folder with: 3 copies of your resume, your reference list, your ID, a pen and notepad, any certificates or licenses, and your questions for them.
- Get a good night's sleep. Eat something before you go.

- **Phone or video interview:** find a quiet, well-lit spot with a plain background; charge your device; test the camera, sound, and link ahead of time; dress as you would in person; keep your resume in front of you.

## How to Behave During the Interview

- From the parking lot on, you're being interviewed. Be polite to everyone, including the receptionist and other staff.
- Turn your phone off (not just silent) and put it away before you walk in.
- Greet with a smile, a firm handshake if offered, and eye contact. Use the interviewer's name: "Nice to meet you, Ms. Johnson."
- Wait to be offered a seat. Sit up straight, keep your hands still and visible, and lean slightly forward to show interest.
- Listen to the whole question before answering. It's fine to pause and think. If you don't understand, ask them to repeat or rephrase it.
- Keep answers to 1–2 minutes. Give a specific example, then stop. Rambling is one of the most common reasons people lose an offer.
- Stay positive about every past job, boss, and coworker, even the bad ones.
- Show energy and interest. Employers hire people who want this job, not just a job.
- Close strong: thank them, restate in one sentence why you want the job, and ask about next steps.

## What Not to Do or Say

| Don't | Why it hurts | Do instead |
|---|---|---|
| Arrive late or very early | Signals you'll be unreliable | Arrive 10–15 minutes early; if late, call ahead |
| Criticize a past boss, coworker, or company | They assume you'll talk about them that way too | "It wasn't the right fit, and I learned a lot." |
| Say "I'll do anything" or "I just need a job" | Sounds desperate and unfocused | Name why this specific job fits you |
| Ask about pay, breaks, or time off in the first interview | Sounds like you care more about the perks than the work | Wait until they bring it up or make an offer |
| Overshare: personal problems, money troubles, family drama, health, religion, politics | Makes them worry about distractions | Keep every answer about work |
| Lie or exaggerate | Background and reference checks catch it | Be honest and brief |
| Use slang, swearing, or overly casual talk | Comes across as unprofessional | Speak as you would to a respected church leader or teacher |

| Don’t | Why it hurts | Do instead |
|---|---|---|
| Check your phone, chew gum, or smoke right before | Distracting; smoke smell lingers | Phone off, no gum, no smoking beforehand |
| Answer “What’s your weakness?” with “I’m a perfectionist” or “I have none” | Sounds rehearsed or dishonest | Name a real one and how you’re improving |
| Say “No” when asked if you have questions | Looks uninterested | Always ask 2–3 questions |
| Bring friends, family, or children inside | Unprofessional | Have them wait elsewhere |

**Questions they shouldn’t ask:** employers generally may not ask about your age, religion, marital status, children or pregnancy plans, national origin, or disability. If one comes up, you can answer the concern behind it calmly: “I’m able to work the schedule this job requires.”

## Common Questions and How to Answer

| Question | What they want to hear |
|---|---|
| Tell me about yourself. | Your 30-second introduction, focused on work, not your life story |
| Why do you want this job? | Something specific about the job or company, plus how you fit |
| What are your strengths? | Two strengths with a quick example of each |
| What’s a weakness? | A real one and what you’re doing to improve it |
| Tell me about a time you had a conflict at work. | One of your prepared stories: calm, respectful, resolved |
| Why did you leave your last job? / Explain this gap. | One honest sentence, then turn to what you’re ready to do now |
| Where do you see yourself in a few years? | Growing with this company, learning more, taking on responsibility |
| What schedule can you work? | Honest and as flexible as you can be |
| Why should we hire you? | Your top 2–3 reasons, tied to what the posting asks for |

## Questions You Should Ask Them

Asking good questions shows you’re serious and helps you decide if the job is right for you. Pick 3–4.

### About the job

- What does a typical day or shift look like?
- What are the most important things for the person in this job to do well in the first 90 days?

- How is training handled for new employees?
- What are the biggest challenges someone in this role will face?

### About the team and company

- Who would I be working with and reporting to?
- What do you like most about working here?
- What makes someone successful on this team?
- Are there opportunities to grow or move up for someone who does well?

### About next steps (always ask one of these)

- What are the next steps in your hiring process?
- When do you expect to make a decision?
- Is there anything about my background you'd like me to explain further?

Save for after an offer: pay, benefits, overtime, paid time off, and start date. If they bring up pay first, it's fine to discuss it.

## After the Interview

- **Same day:** send a short thank-you email or handwritten note to each person who interviewed you. Mention one thing you talked about and repeat your interest.
- Write notes on what they asked and how you answered, so you can improve next time.
- **Follow up once** if you haven't heard back by the date they gave (or in about a week): a polite call or email asking whether a decision has been made.
- Keep applying until you have a written offer and a start date.
- If you don't get it, thank them and politely ask if they have any advice for you. Some employers will keep you in mind for the next opening.
- When you get an offer, confirm the pay, schedule, and start date in writing, and report new income to any benefits office as required.

# Quick Reference

Phone numbers and hours change; call to confirm before you visit.

| Need | Who to contact | Phone / web |
|---|---|---|
| Any kind of help, 24/7 | 211 | Dial 211 · text ZIP to 898-211 |
| Nearest job center (anywhere in U.S.) | CareerOneStop | 1-877-872-5627 · careeronestop.org/localhelp |
| Job center – Cecil, MD | Susquehanna Workforce Center, Elkton | 410-996-0550 |
| Job center – Harford, MD | Susquehanna Workforce Center, Swan Creek | 410-272-5400 |
| Job center – Kent, MD | Kent County American Job Center, Chestertown | 410-778-3525 |
| Job center – New Castle, DE | Delaware JobLink, Newark / Wilmington | 302-368-6622 / 302-761-8085 |
| Job center – Lancaster, PA | PA CareerLink Lancaster County | 717-509-5613 |
| Job center – Chester, PA | PA CareerLink Chester County, Exton | 610-280-1010 |
| Unemployment – MD / DE / PA | BEACON / DE Division of UI / PA UC | 667-207-6520 / 302-761-8446 / 1-888-313-7284 |
| Senior job training (55+) – Cecil, Harford | CWI Works – Maryland (SCSEP) | 410-801-6088 |
| Senior job training (55+) – Kent | MD Dept. of Labor SCSEP line | 410-767-2396 |
| Senior job training (55+) – DE | Goodwill of Delaware and Delaware County | 1-866-317-2299 |
| Senior job training (55+) – PA | AARP Foundation SCSEP | 1-855-850-2525 |
| Working while on Social Security | Social Security Administration | 1-800-772-1213 |
| Reentry help – MD / DE | MD Labor Re-Entry Initiative / ReEntry Delaware | 410-767-2173 / 302-275-2779 |
| Record clearing – DE | Office of Defense Services / Clean Slate Delaware | ods.delaware.gov/expungements · cleanslatede.org |
| Record clearing – PA | MidPenn Legal / Legal Aid of SE PA | 1-800-326-9177 / 877-429-5994 |
| Federal Bonding Program | Through your job center | bonds4jobs.com |

| Need | Who to contact | Phone / web |
|---|---|---|
| Job training, ages 16–24 | Job Corps (Wilmington center 302-575-1710) | 1-800-733-5627 |
| Job readiness – DE | Goodwill Opportunity Hub, Wilmington | 302-761-4640 |
| Report a job scam | Federal Trade Commission | reportfraud.ftc.gov |
| Job search group, any faith | Find a Better Job (self-reliance group) | Ask your bishop |

# Important Disclaimers and Sources

## Please Read Before You Rely on This Guide

- **General information only.** This guide is for general reference. It is not legal, medical, financial, tax or immigration advice, and it does not create a lawyer–client, counselor–client or any other professional relationship.
- **No guarantee of eligibility or services.** Listing a program does not mean you qualify or that space, money or appointments are available. Each agency makes its own decisions.
- **Information changes.** Details were checked in October 2026 against official and organization websites. Phone numbers, addresses, hours, income limits and dollar amounts change often, sometimes without notice. Call to confirm before you travel, apply or make a decision.
- **Not an endorsement.** Organizations are listed only because they serve people in our area. The Wilmington Delaware Stake and The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints do not endorse, sponsor or take responsibility for any outside organization, its staff or its services.
- **Not an official Church publication.** This guide was compiled by local volunteers. Quotations from scripture, hymns, Church leaders and others are included for encouragement; you do not need to share any faith to use any resource in it.
- **Emergencies.** If anyone is in immediate danger, call **911**. For a mental-health or suicide crisis, call or text **988**. For anything else, dial **211**.
- **Employment decisions are the employer's.** No program in this guide can guarantee a job, interview, wage, or training slot. Sample letters and answers are examples to adapt, not scripts that ensure a result.
- **Criminal records and record clearing.** Laws on background checks, expungement, shielding, and sealing are summarized in general terms. Eligibility depends on your exact record; get advice from legal aid before you rely on a record being cleared.
- **Benefits and Social Security.** Earnings can affect SNAP, Medicaid, unemployment, SSI, SSDI, and Social Security retirement benefits. Report income as required and confirm with the agency before accepting work.

## Found Something Out of Date?

Tell your ward or stake self-reliance specialist or your bishop so the next edition can be corrected.

## Main Sources

- Maryland Department of Labor — Susquehanna and Upper Shore workforce pages; SCSEP fact sheet PY2025–2026; Re-Entry Initiative; veteran services

- Delaware Department of Labor and Delaware JobLink; DSAAPD employment (SCSEP); Goodwill of Delaware and Delaware County
- PA CareerLink Lancaster and Chester; AARP Foundation SCSEP locator; Lancaster County Office of Aging; Chester County Department of Aging Services
- Cecil College, Harford Community College, Chesapeake College, Delaware Tech, HACC, Thaddeus Stevens, Delaware County Community College
- Maryland Criminal Record Screening Practices Act summary; Community Legal Services Clean Slate 3.0 FAQ; Spotlight Delaware (Clean Slate status, May 2026); Federal Bonding Program (bonds4jobs.com)
- Social Security Administration 2026 COLA fact sheet; state minimum wage pages (MD, DE, PA)
- 2025 federal SNAP work-requirement changes (NCSL); Federal Trade Commission job-scam guidance
- Job Corps (jobcorps.gov; Wilmington center); Career Wardrobe locations; library websites for each county
- Find a Better Job — churchofjesuschrist.org/self-reliance